2.4 War at Sea

When you're used to walking on land, it can be hard to adjust to the tossing and swaying of a boat. Some people refer to this as "getting your sea legs." Sailors in the Continental Navy were about to get theirs.

MAIN IDEA The Continental Navy needed teamwork, determination, and strategy as it faced almost impossible odds against Britain's Royal Navy.

ATTACKS ON MERCHANT SHIPS

On land, Americans had the advantage of fighting on familiar terrain, or landforms and other physical features. And even though the British sent great numbers of troops to fight in North America, they were spread out across vast distances, so the Continental Army often faced smaller numbers of British troops at a time. In this way, it was able to hold its own.

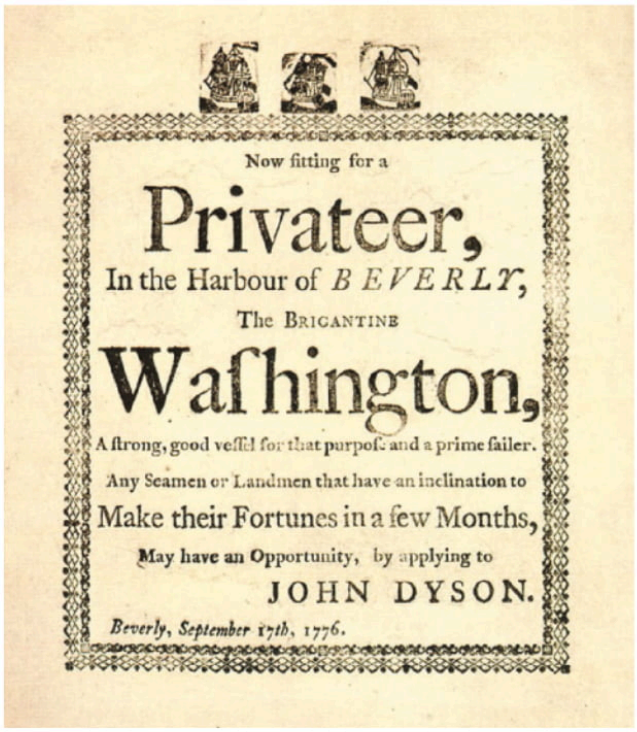
The war at sea was a different story. Through the efforts of John Adams, the Continental Congress had established the Continental Navy in 1775, but the navy never had many ships. In contrast, Britain's Royal Navy was the largest and most powerful in the world, capable of causing great damage to the Americans' forces and economy. Even as the American Revolution began, British naval vessels had blockaded American harbors. Now they were attacking both American naval and merchant ships. The tiny Continental Navy could not hope to match its enemy's strength and resources.

Quickly building up and supporting a naval fleet was much more difficult than recruiting troops for land conflict. However, Benjamin Franklin's visit to France paid off. The French and Spanish navies helped swell the ranks of the Continental Navy.

Americans also turned to privateers—privately owned ships authorized to participate in warfare—to help protect their own shipping industry and damage Britain's. The Continental Congress granted privateers official permission to attack any British naval and merchant ships they encountered. During the war, as many as 2,000 vessels were put into use for privateering.

Privateer crews included a number of African-American sailors, both enslaved and free. Slave catchers rarely tried to capture runaway slaves who had stowed away on a ship. And the pay onboard was good, even though all privateer sailors worked in dangerous conditions. In fact, they were often captured and taken as prisoners of war.

Teenage African-American crewmember **James Forten** was taken aboard a British ship when it captured his vessel, the *Royal Louis*. The British captain assigned Forten to care for his young son, and the two became fast friends. As a result, the


Now fitting for a
Privateer,
In the Harbour of *BEVERLY*,
The BRIGANTINE
Washington,
A ſtrong, good veſſel for that purpoſe and a prime ſailer.
Any Seamen or Landmen that have an inclination to
Make their Fortunes in a few Months,
May have an Opportunity, by applying to
JOHN DYSON.
Beverly, September 17th, 1776.

Calling All Able Sailors
This handbill advertised for experienced sailors to sail with the *Washington*, a vessel that went on to capture several enemy ships.

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The Ordeal of John Paul Jones
Illustrator Anton Otto Fischer captures the drama on the *Bonhomme Richard* as John Paul Jones (background, right) and his crew fight to keep sailors on the British ship *Serapis* from boarding their ship. About 150 people were killed on each side in this battle.



captain's son asked his father to grant Forten his freedom instead of turning him over to a prison ship. The captain offered Forten a chance to return to Britain with them, but Forten refused. He believed in the principles of the American Revolution, especially the natural rights of freedom and the opportunity for democracy.

JOHN PAUL JONES

What the Continental Navy lacked in ships it made up for in determination, strategy, and sheer heroism. One American captain, **John Paul Jones**, had all three of these strengths. In September 1779, Jones was in command of a ship called the *Bonhomme Richard* when he encountered the British ship *Serapis*. The *Serapis* was escorting British merchant ships carrying military supplies. Jones attacked the *Serapis*, and the battle was on.

Disaster struck for the American ship when its main gun battery exploded. Soon after, the *Bonhomme Richard* caught fire and was damaged beyond repair. Legend has it that with both ships fighting side by side, the British called on Jones to surrender. But he yelled back, "I have not yet begun to fight!" The battle raged on, and soon it fell to the British to surrender. Jones boarded and took control of the *Serapis*. In a war with few victories for the Continental Navy, Jones's success boosted American morale as the conflict moved into its final stage.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** How was the Continental Navy able to hold its own against Britain's Royal Navy?
2. **ANALYZE CAUSE AND EFFECT** How were France and Spain affected by the war at sea?
3. **MAKE INFERENCES** What do you think James Forten hoped to gain by fighting to uphold the American principles of freedom?

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